

Passages - Anaximander

Gods give structure to the world, appear as characters in all the great tales, justify the power of monarchies, are identified with that power, are invoked in judgments by individuals and groups, and serve as guarantors of law.

All things originate from one another, and vanish into one another

According to necessity;

They give to each other justice and recompense for injustice

In conformity with the order of Time.

The very unpredictability of meteorological phenomena reflected divine freedom. To seek a naturalistic interpretation for these phenomena, one independent of the gods, represented an enormous break with a religious reading of the world.

Plato in the *Phaedo* has Socrates say that he maintains that the Earth is a sphere, but he adds,

"I myself should never be able to prove it."

This passage in the *Phaedo* is the oldest direct evidence we have of the belief in a spherical Earth.

It is nothing more than the combination of curiosity with clarity of intelligence.

Anaximander in some way invents the open space of the cosmos. The ramifications of this conceptual innovation are immense.

The challenge lies not in finding answers, but in asking the right questions.

Instead of recognizing the written word, one could simply pronounce it and recognize it by the sound, even without

preliminary knowledge of the particular written word in the text.

The first technology in human history capable of preserving a copy of the human voice was born.

In the field of knowledge, the discovery is that allowing free criticism and questioning, granting anyone the right to take part in discussions, and taking all proposals seriously does not result in an inconclusive cacophony.

On the contrary, it leads to the rejection of the weak hypotheses and the emergence of the best ideas.

Cultural "purity" is invoked even today only by the least-intelligent citizens, terrified by the arrival of peoples different from them.

But reducing science to a predictive technique is to confuse science with its technical applications, or to mistake a characteristic verification tool with science itself.

Science cannot be reduced to quantitative predictions.

It cannot be reduced to calculation techniques, operational protocols, or the hypothesis-deduction method.

Observations and assumptions can exist only within an already largely structured system of thinking, one that is a priori riddled with errors. We have no certain point of departure.

The central problem of cultural relativism, understood in this radical sense, is that it is self-contradictory. It is true that there is no notion of truth outside history and culture. It is precisely for this reason, though, that we cannot do without truth values. From what vantage point are they

speaking, those who deny the meaning of these values? Are they placing themselves outside of culture in order to preach that it is impossible to exist outside of culture? Outside of history in order to preach that it is impossible to exist outside of history? Aren't they expressing a judgment of value or merit, which, as such, by their own terms, has only a relative value?

The point is that we are always immersed in a given culture, and it is impossible to step outside. The notion of truth does not exist outside of our universe of dis-course, and precisely for this reason we cannot do without the notion of truth. Even if we seek to deny it, we speak always in terms of this notion. It is only from within our domain of discourse that we can speak, make truth claims, and formulate judgments.

Pope Benedict XVI, for instance, often says that to save ourselves from the relativistic drift, we have to defend the infallible Truth. "Truth," in this context, obviously means the particular truth of those who are speaking.

Anaximander's fundamental lesson: if you want to truly advance the path of knowledge, you must not just revere your master, study, and build on his teachings. You must seek out his mistakes.

But a deeper contradiction remains unresolved and is doomed to return. Conflict is inevitable. Mythic-religious thought relies on the acceptance of absolute truths that must not be questioned, while the very nature of scientific thinking demands that truths, particularly those accepted uncritically, be questioned.

Karl Marx: religion does not express the interests of society as a whole, but only of the ruling class, for whom it is a means of perpetuating the oppression upon the rest of society.

Jaynes argues that the solution that emerged to prevent the scattering of the group was an introjection of the dominant male's figure, whose "voice," ordering what to do, became "heard" by his subjects even in his absence. The voice of the sovereign continues to be heard and revered even after his death. His corpse, preserved for as long as possible, still "speaks," and evolves into the statue of the god, worshiped at the center of every ancient city. The sovereign's home—that is, the home of the god's statue—becomes the temple at the heart of every ancient city.* The system stabilizes over the course of millennia and determines the social and psychological structure of ancient civilizations.

Language does not just reflect reality. Most often, it creates reality. The priest who says, "I now pronounce you man and wife," the judge who says "guilty," the faculty that says, "I now bestow upon you the title of doctor," a parliament that approves a law, Napoléon speaking of honor and glory to French soldiers in the shadow of the pyramids, an American presidential candidate delivering his vision for the future, a minister preaching in church on Sunday--these people do not just describe reality; they make something real by means of language.

"Tradition" is nothing else than the codified thinking of human beings who lived at times when ignorance was even greater than

ours.

Uncritical acceptance is the post to which we are bound, the cornerstone of our ignorance that prevents us from setting off to explore elsewhere and seeking something truer.